

# HOUSE . . . . . No. 524

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## The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

*Antonio F. D. Cabral*

*To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:*

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act to require school attendance up to age 18 or until graduation.

PETITION OF:

| NAME:                       | DISTRICT/ADDRESS:    | DATE ADDED:      |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|------------------|
| <i>Antonio F. D. Cabral</i> | <i>13th Bristol</i>  | <i>1/14/2025</i> |
| <i>Priscila S. Sousa</i>    | <i>6th Middlesex</i> | <i>2/24/2025</i> |

# HOUSE . . . . . No. 524

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By Representative Cabral of New Bedford, a petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 524) of Antonio F. D. Cabral and Priscila S. Sousa relative to requiring school attendance up to age 18 or until graduation. Education.

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[SIMILAR MATTER FILED IN PREVIOUS SESSION  
SEE HOUSE, NO. 3811 OF 2023-2024.]

## The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

\_\_\_\_\_  
In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court  
(2025-2026)  
\_\_\_\_\_

An Act to require school attendance up to age 18 or until graduation.

*Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:*

1           SECTION 1. Section 1 of chapter 76 of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2022  
2   Official Edition, is hereby amended by:

3           (a)     striking out, in lines 1 to 2, the words “between the minimum and maximum ages  
4   established for school attendance by the board of education” and inserting in place thereof the  
5   following words:

6           “ages of 6 and 18, having completed at least the twelfth grade, high school equivalency  
7   test, or whichever comes first”.; and

8           (b)     inserting after the word “herewith”, in line 58, the following words:

9 “, provided that no student over the age of 16 shall face criminal penalties for failure to  
10 attend school through the mandatory age for school attendance”.

11 SECTION 2. Section 1B of chapter 69 of the General Laws, as so appearing, is hereby  
12 amended by inserting before the period, in line 120, the following words:

13 “, provided, however, that all children under the age of 18 shall be required to attend  
14 school if they have not graduated from high school or completed the high school equivalency  
15 test”.

16 SECTION 3. Chapter 76 of the General Laws, as so appearing, is hereby amended by  
17 inserting after section 21 the following section:

18 Section 22. Commission to Study Barriers to High School Graduation.

19 (a) Establishment of Commission. There shall be a special commission, referred to as  
20 the ‘High School Graduation Commission’. Said commission shall—

21 (1) investigate and study barriers to high school graduation; and  
22 (2) make recommendations regarding the identification of students at risk of dropping  
23 out of high school and the targeting of services and programs that will ensure all students can  
24 graduate from high school.

25 (b) Members.

26 (1) The commission shall be chaired by the secretary of education or the secretary’s  
27 designee.

(2) The commissioner of the department of higher education or the commissioner's designee and the commissioner of the department of elementary and secondary education or the commissioner's designee shall each be members.

(3) The governor shall appoint 4 members, one of whom shall be nominated by the Massachusetts Teachers Association and one of whom shall be nominated by the American Federation of Teachers of Massachusetts.

(4) The speaker of the house shall appoint one member and the senate president shall appoint one member.

(c) Reporting Requirements. The commission shall report its findings and any legislation necessary to implement said findings to the governor, the clerks of the senate and house of representatives, the senate and house of representatives committees on ways and means, the senate and house of representatives committees on education, six months upon effective date of the act. The commission report shall include but not be limited to: an analysis of the student populations who are at the highest risk of dropping out, mechanisms to identify students who are at risk of dropping out, barriers to high school graduation and evidence based services that reduce and eliminate barriers to high school graduation. In making its recommendations the commission shall consider among other issues—

(1) grades, attendance patterns, disciplinary issues, family and environmental factors, breaks or gaps in education, teen parenthood, limited English proficiency and disabilities that may indicate a student is at risk of not completing high school;

(2) mechanisms and information technology that can be used to identify students at risk of dropping out and track students' progress once identified;

- (3) appropriate benchmarks for periodic review of students' progress;
- (4) wrap around support services designed to effectively target and alleviate or eliminate barriers for students completing high school;
- (5) methods to reengage students who have left school;
- (6) dedicated tutoring and academic services for students who have gaps in education as a result of moving, illness, absences, disciplinary issues or immigration;
- (7) emotional support services and resources for students at risk of dropping out; and
- (8) recommendations for mechanisms to emphasize the importance of high school graduation for all students.

SECTION 4. Sections 1 to 3 of this Act shall become effective on the next school year calendar after passage.